

cooling TOWER

✱ Arvind Patel, 54

Project A natural water cooler and a refrigerator that keeps vegetables fresh for long

Can-do Icon Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel

250 units

of Patel's water cooler have been sold by the Gujarat Energy Development Agency



SMOOTH INNOVATOR: Patel (right) with his water cooler-cum-air cooler-cum-refrigerator



SHAIKSH RAVAL

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It's very tough discovering an enterprising industrialist who will place complete faith in me.

ARVIND PATEL, Entrepreneur

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It was in 1996. Arvind Patel had high fever and to contain it, he put a water-soaked napkin on his forehead. It was a day of sweltering heat and Patel was sleeping under a fan. As the water in the napkin started evaporating because of the fan, the all-rolled-in-one low-end technician found that the napkin had become cold enough to send a chill down his spine.

was when he thought that following the same principle of evaporation, he could make a natural water cooler—one that would not require an external energy source.

The water cooler cools water to 23 degrees celsius when the outside temperature is 44 degrees. It has a copper drum which is wrapped in a copper coil covered with viscose cloth. An overhead tank fills water in

the drum while at the same time the water passes through the coil. A connection also makes water drip on the viscose-covered coil. A tap is linked to the coil to allow one to collect drinking water. Water remains stored both in the drum and the coil. The Gujarat Energy Development Agency (GEDA) has sold 250 units of Patel's patented natural water cooler at Rs 25,000 a piece after buying them from a local industrialist whom Patel had given a manufacturing licence.

Patel has also designed a refrigerator which can store vegetables for longer than the normal ones. While normal refrigerators can maintain the freshness of vegetables for only two-three days, Patel's model, which can store everything except ice cream and milk and doesn't make ice, retains the freshness for more than three days. Besides this, Patel is also dabbling in making a three-in-one—an air cooler with a water cooler and a refrigeration box inside.

The National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development has sanctioned a Rs 1 lakh loan to Patel to perfect the design of a one-tonne refrigerator, which requires electricity and is targeted at farmers and small food processors. It has passed the tests of the Indian Council of Agricultural Research and he has applied for a patent.

The busy innovator lives in a small tenement in Maninagar area with his wife Jayshree, son Jaimin and daughter Richa. Jaimin, 20, is studying engineering and Richa, 18, is doing graduation in physiotherapy. Though Patel's inventions have been highlighted by the media, he is struggling to find finance for his projects. “It's very tough to discover an enterprising industrialist who will put complete faith in me for the best results,” Patel says. Not that he lets it either deter his spirit or affect his innovation. His best, he insists, is yet to come.

by Uday Mahur